Move where? I wondered. Pathankot? Kashmir? Are they going to finish me off?

The Panama smoker told the man who came with the message that he needed fifteen more minutes. ‘We are almost through. Please give us a little more time.’

He then turned to me and said with a sense of great urgency, ‘Behave and tell us the plot without breaking in the middle. If you do that, we will release you immediately. Or else you will be taken to hell for further investigation.’

My head was spinning, but I tried my best not to show any emotion. Any hell would be better than this, I told myself. The IB officer was yelling at me to talk. I realised that he was loyal to his masters, whoever that was. He wanted his concocted tale recorded in my voice to be presented to his bosses. I was not going to yield as I knew he did not have much time left to deal with me.

Something told me that the IB’s role in this case was getting over, and that I would be handed over to, as one of the interrogators had said, the CBI. In about twenty minutes after his first entry, the messenger came running in again, shouting, ‘You know these fellows, they are here. They’ve already called thrice. If we do not move now, we have to face the consequences.’

‘Ok, let us move,’ said the IB man. Then, turning to me, he added, ‘Mr Nambi, please remember that you should tell your new interrogators more or less the same things we asked you to say. If you don’t, you are going to feel really bad about it.’

They took me out of the room, on to the ground floor. Someone handed me a polythene bag, saying it had come from my home. I did not bother to look what was in it. There were four or five constables and a few others taking me to a police jeep. Before I got in, the R&AW officer came up to me, took my hand and said, ‘Good luck’. I looked around for the other interrogators, but could not see any.

They asked me to get into a police jeep that was to take me—and the other accused—to the Pallipuram police camp in Trivandrum where the